



Testing times: East Bengal has blamed poor refereeing for the team's struggles in the ongoing ISL, where it currently sits at the bottom of the standings with just one point from seven matches. *Pics: FSDL*

EAST BENGAL ON A VAR FOOTING

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East Bengal Club has sought the All India Football Federation's (AIFF) intervention for the implementation of VAR technology as a solution to improving refereeing standards in the Indian Super League (ISL). Club officials have blamed poor supervision for the team's struggles in the ongoing ISL, where it currently sits at the bottom of the standings with just one point from seven matches.

The flashpoint came during its seventh outing, in which East Bengal received two red cards before managing to secure a goalless draw against city rival Mohammedan Sporting. The issue was discussed at a recent meeting of East Bengal's executive committee, and the club decided to "approach the AIFF president, Kalyan Chaubey, to complain against the unjust refereeing decisions and the installation of VAR technology," said one of the club's key functionaries, Debabrata (Nitu) Sarkar.

"We want the Federation to act against the poor standard of refereeing in the ISL. Our fans, supporters, and even former players are voicing their disapproval against debatable refereeing decisions. We will be writing a letter to the president of AIFF, looking for a

solution against the discrimination East Bengal is repeatedly facing," said Sarkar. "It is high time the AIFF started installing VAR in ISL stadiums. When the clubs can spend an average of ₹70 to ₹80 crore on team selection, why can't we spend a little more to ensure the implementation of VAR technology?" he added.

Although clubs have long demanded the introduction of VAR, the extraordinary costs associated with procuring and maintaining the popular video technology have reportedly restrained ISL organisers from implementing it. East Bengal will hope its appeal expedites the process.

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